50TH ANNIVERSARY

CINEMA
2015-2025

SOUTHERN DHAMAKA

This was the decade the South Indian film caught the national imagination and OTT showed viewers what choice looked like



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Could the Badshahs of Bollywood be getting old? That was a question we grappled with, as the three Khans—Shahrukh, Aamir and Salman—turned 50 in 2015. But then if Amitabh Bachchan, 20 years their senior, could still be going strong with *Piku* in 2015, *Pink* in 2016 and *Kalki 2898 AD* in 2024, why not the trio? And so Aamir gave us a *Dangal* in 2016, SRK double delighted with *Pathan* and *Jawan* in 2023, and Salman tripled the excitement with *Bajrangi Bhaijaan* (2015), *Sultan* (2016) and *Tiger Zinda Hai* (2017).

But it wasn't the Bollywood film that first stormed the Rs 1,000 crore club—that honour went to three films from the South—*Baahubali: The Conclusion* (2017), *KGF: Chapter 2* (2022) and *Pushpa 2: The Rule* (2024), besides the hugely popular *RRR* (2022). Dubbed versions had long conquered the language barrier; in scale, audacity and epic proportion, the Hindi heartland had seen nothing like a southern blockbuster before. Almost overnight, Prabhas, Allu Arjun, Yash, Ram Charan became household names across the coun-